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MOVING FAMILIES TO SELF-SUFFICIENCY: THE GAUTREAUX ASSISTED HOUSING PROGRAM

by David Hudson

"As the Chicago Housing Authority moves ahead with its touted 'redevelopment plan,' the lessons of the Gautreaux Program become more relevant. Whether a unit is rehabilitated or not, the enervating effects of segregation need to be accounted for."

Unless otherwise credited, the empirical evidence in this article is attributed to Gautreaux Program work files kept by the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development (HUD) and the Leadership Council for Metropolitan Open Communities.

In the summer of 1966, when much of Chicago was focused upon the arrival of Dr. King, Dorothy Gautreaux and other public housing residents filed a lawsuit that resulted in one of the nation's most successful desegregation programs. Thirty-four years later, more than 8,500 families--24,000 individuals--have moved out of public housing to nonsegregated communities throughout the six county Chicagoland region.

While this may seem quite remarkable, the Gautreaux Assisted Housing Program's most important achievement, and most germane, was that it illustrated there were and are a substantial number of public housing families who are willing to move into mostly white suburban communities in order to seek better opportunities. In light of Chicago's recently announced "redevelopment plan" for the Chicago Housing Authority (CHA), it is worthwhile to examine the Gautreaux Assisted Housing Program and what factors can account for its success.

The suit filed in 1966 charged that the Chicago Housing Authority (CHA) and the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development (HUD) had practiced de facto segregation by operating a racially segregated public housing program. *See Gautreaux v. The Chicago Housing Authority et al.*, 296 F. Supp. 907 (N.D.Ill. 1969). Discrimination in site selection and tenant assignment was alleged, and in 1969, the court ruled in favor of the CHA residents. As a result of this ruling, the plaintiffs, led by lead counsel Alexander Polikoff, sought region-wide relief. The United States Supreme Court handed down a decision which required HUD to use its Section 8 program to provide relief. See *Hills v.*

Gautreaux, 425 U.S. 284 (1975). The Section 8 Program, recently renamed the Housing Choice Voucher Program, provides financial assistance to families who live in private rental housing. The family pays 30% of their income towards rent and HUD pays the balance. In 1976, the Leadership Council for Metropolitan Open Communities was selected to implement a demonstration project to determine the feasibility of this relief.

According to the Gautreaux Consent Decree, CHA families could only move to areas that were less than 30% African American. *See Gautreaux v. CHA*, 304 F. Supp. 736, *enforcing* 296 F. Supp. 907 (N.D.Ill. 1969). Given the requirements of the consent decree, the Gautreaux Program had to be administered in profoundly different ways than conventional Section 8 programs. Traditionally, Section 8 programs rely solely on public housing families' ability to locate housing. Typically, families are inexperienced housing consumers, operating in a discriminatory dual housing market which, at best, results in continued segregation, and at worst, results in increased segregation. A study conducted by the Voorhees Center found that of the five Chicagoland communities that have the highest concentration of Section 8 residents, three--South Shore, Austin, and West Englewood--have African American populations near 90%. *See Nathalie P. Voorhees Center for Neighborhood and Community Improvement, "The Plan to Voucher Out Public Housing: An analysis of the Chicago experience and a case study of the proposal to redevelop the Cabrini-Green public housing area"* (1997).

The Gautreaux Program adopted various affirmative measures to adhere to the terms of the consent decree and avoid resegregation. For instance, outreach to landlords became an integral part of Gautreaux's success. When the program began, suburban and many city landlords were less than enthusiastic about renting to African American public housing families. While many today still won't, over the duration of the Gautreaux Program, a number of landlords were willing to meet with the Leadership Council and gradually accepted public housing families as tenants. Once a relationship between the Council and landlords was established, program implementation efforts were expanded to communities throughout the six county region.

These outreach efforts were predicated on the counseling the Leadership Council was providing families. Counselors reinforced the importance of access to good schools and safe neighborhoods. Within this context, public housing families recognized the positive impact of leaving public housing and moving to nonsegregated communities. This type of counseling took advantage of the families' initiative.

It is also important to note that the Gautreaux Program was entirely voluntary. It was up to the families to decide if they were willing to participate in the Program. The Leadership Council provided the subsequent support, but it was the families' initiative that started the process. Due to the overwhelming interest in the program, on two occasions, 15,000 public housing families tried to register for 2,000 program slots.

Once these families left public housing, their initial determination manifested itself in many ways. In 1990, Northwestern University's Center for Urban Affairs and Policy Research published a study on the Gautreaux Program. The study focused upon three areas: satisfaction with new community, social integration, and employment. The study, while confirming that the first step in making public housing residents self-sufficient is moving them from segregated housing developments, highlighted many important trends. For instance, the study found that "suburban movers [Gautreaux clients who moved to suburban municipalities] were about 13 percent more likely than city movers to have a job post-move, even after we accounted for the effects of individual attributes [education, effects of long-term poverty]. Further, among respondents who had never been employed before moving, 46 percent of suburban movers had a job after moving while only 30 percent of city movers did." *See Center for Urban Affairs and Policy Research, Northwestern University, "The Gautreaux Program: An Experiment in Racial and Economic Integration"* (1990).

These findings are remarkable when one considers the Gautreaux Program had no formal apparatus to increase employment amongst its clients. The

increased rate of employment is mostly attributable to the motivation of individual clients.

The Northwestern study also contained reassuring findings for minority families looking to move to suburban municipalities, stating, "We found little difference in the social integration of city and suburban movers. Both groups reported about the same level of interaction with neighbors, and viewed them as friendly." Yet as a result of the corresponding communities,"suburban movers were more likely to have white friends than city movers."

The first conclusion one draws from these findings is that many white communities are amenable to integration. It would be an overstatement to claim that most suburban municipalities are enthusiastic about integration. For example, half of the Gautreaux clients that moved to the suburbs experienced some form of racial harassment. Yet it would be accurate to say that housing options for African Americans have expanded greatly over the last two decades.

The findings of the Center for Urban Affairs and Policy Research study also confirm the role played by counseling and community outreach programs in moving families out of public housing and to self-sufficiency. Clearly, there is a need to expunge misinformation regarding how landlords view residents of public housing and how residents of public housing view their housing options. Many of the Gautreaux clients were understandably ambivalent about moving to suburban municipalities. This ambivalence was founded on decades of racial tensions, riots, and fears of the unknown. Landlords, as well, believed that public housing residents would make terrible tenants. Given the portrayal of public housing in Chicago, it certainly is understandable how one could arrive at that conclusion. But if these misconceptions go unaddressed, the result invariably will be continued segregation.

The Northwestern study makes clear that, with the combination of a motivated public housing resident, counseling, and outreach, this ambivalence can be overcome--public housing families who move to outlying municipalities feel the same level of social integration as families who stay in the city. In addition, while simply moving families out of public housing positively influences their employment prospects, public housing families that move to the suburbs experience markedly better long - term employment chances than those that stay in the city. This finding is even more remarkable considering that suburbs often times present additional barriers (i.e., lack of public transportation).

While these results are quite encouraging, they have yet to profoundly change the way things are done in Chicago. For instance, families who use Housing Choice Vouchers, formerly Section 8 certificates, are only protected from source of income discrimination within the city of Chicago. Outside of the city, if a landlord does not want to rent to a family because they are using these vouchers, he can legally exclude them. If the goal of public housing reform is to move families to self-sufficiency, this presents a serious problem in light of the Northwestern study. Furthermore, given the current paucity of affordable housing in the region, public housing families do not have the flexibility to look in many places. Ideally, the enactment of laws or ordinances that would include Housing Choice Voucher recipients as a protected class and also increase the number of available affordable units would go a long way towards aiding public housing families. In the short term, we must educate landlords about public housing residents and the Housing Choice Voucher program.

As CHA moves ahead with its touted "redevelopment plan," the lessons of the Gautreaux Program become more relevant. Whether a unit is rehabilitated or not, the enervating effects of segregation need to be accounted for. Changing the interior of a unit or even razing an entire structure does not create jobs. The Gautreaux Program illustrates that with the proper outreach and counseling tools, public housing families can move to self-sufficiency. Public housing reform should be about people, not buildings.

■ *David Hudson is the Director of Communications and Development for the Leadership Council for Metropolitan Open Communities, a not-for-profit organization dedicated to eliminating discrimination and segregation in metropolitan Chicago housing markets.*